

WHAT WOULD MY IDEAL LIFE LOOK LIKE?

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the negative impact of the current environment on recovery from addiction.
2. Clarify and prioritize life values and goals.
3. Increase awareness of the effects of addictive behavior on achieving values and goals.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE LIVING ENVIRONMENT DEFICIENCIES

- A Working Recovery Plan
- Assessing My Needs
- Assessing Self-Care Deficits
- Building My Support Network
- Filling in the Gaps
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Setting and Pursuing Goals in Recovery
- What Do I Need and How Do I Get It?
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEM FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “What Would My Ideal Life Look Like?” activity is written for clients who are having difficulty establishing concrete goals for life in recovery. Its approach is to guide the client in establishing what his/her ideal would be in each of several life domains, then determining the difference between the current situation and that ideal, and what action is necessary to achieve the ideal. The exercise then leads the client in thinking about whether addictive behaviors will help or hinder him/her in achieving these ideals, and it challenges rationalizations, working to increase cognitive dissonance and break down denial and minimization. Follow-up could include establishing plans and timelines for some of the actions defined in this exercise, keeping a journal, and sharing outcomes of those plans with the therapist and treatment group.

WHAT WOULD MY IDEAL LIFE LOOK LIKE?

This assignment will help you identify the benefits of sobriety that mean the most to you personally. It will also help you set some goals above and beyond recovery and focus on what changes in your life would make you happiest.

1. Do you have a clear idea of what your ideal life would be like? Please think about this for a moment, then fill in the following sections with short descriptions of your ideal life in each area.
 - a. Where would you live? _____
 - b. What would your marital/family situation be? _____
 - c. What would your work be? _____
 - d. What would be your proudest achievements? _____

 - e. What would your hobbies and leisure activities be? _____

 - f. How would other people think of you? _____

2. Now, let's see what it would take to get from where you are today to where you want to be.

- a. Where would you live?

Situation Now

Ideal Situation

What Change is Needed?

- b. What would your marital/family situation be?

Situation Now

Ideal Situation

What Change is Needed?

- c. What would your work be?

Situation Now

Ideal Situation

What Change is Needed?

- d. What would be your proudest achievements?

Situation Now

Ideal Situation

What Change is Needed?

- e. What would your hobbies and leisure activities be?

Situation Now

Ideal Situation

What Change is Needed?

- f. How would other people think of you?

Situation Now

Ideal Situation

What Change is Needed?

3. Concentrating on the changes needed, please consider the impact of abusing alcohol or other drugs, or engaging in other addictive behavior, on your chances of making those changes.

Addictive

Addictive

Behavior

Behavior

No Difference

Will Help

Will Interfere

Either Way

- a. Where you would live:

- b. Marital/family:

- c. Work:

- d. Hobbies/leisure:

- e. What others think:

TOTAL:

4. This time, let's look at the effects of being clean and sober.

Sobriety

Sobriety

No Difference

Will Help

Will Interfere

Either Way

- a. Where you would live:

- b. Marital/family:

- c. Work:

- d. Hobbies/leisure:

- e. What others think:

TOTAL:

5. Some final questions:

a. If drinking, using other drugs, or other addictive behaviors will interfere with your chances of achieving your most cherished dreams, but you keep on practicing the addictive behaviors anyway, are your actions showing that the addiction is actually more important to you than those dreams? If not, how else do you explain this?

b. If someone you knew put a compulsive behavior ahead of his/her dreams and ideals, would you think that he/she had a problem? Would you think it meant he or she was an alcoholic or addict?

c. If this is happening in your life, do the people who know you think you have a problem? If they think you have a problem but you feel you don't, how do you explain this conflict between your values and your actions?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.